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INTERFACE

Info avenues: The Reno Gazette-Journal computer page would like to hear your suggestions, story ideas, tips, letters, flames, whatever. Send e-mail to Guy Richardson on the Internet at **richardsong@nevadanet.com**. For snail-mail: Home Computing, Reno Gazette-Journal, P.O. Box 22000, Reno, Nev. 89520-2000. Fax: 788-6458.

ONLINE THIS WEEK

AMERICA ONLINE
(Keyword for all: AOL LIVE)

- Financial wizard **Nancy Dunnan** charts about her book "Dun & Bradstreet Guide to $Your Investments$ 1998," today at 4 p.m.
- "Catch-22" author **Joseph Heller** talks about his new book "Now And Then: From Coney Island to Here," today at 5 p.m.
- R&B Star **R. Kelly**, "I Believe I Can Fly," has been nominated in five categories for the 40th annual Grammy Awards, today at 8 p.m.
- Composer and performer **Yanni**, Wednesday at 5 p.m.
- Supermodel **Cindy Margolis**, Wednesday at 6 p.m.
- Romance author **Nora Roberts** shares her secrets to a successful romance in print and real life, Wednesday at 8 p.m.

Classes

Computer Base Training/Reno
120 East Plumb, Costco shopping center; 702-689-2900. Reservations required. Cost: $200 unless noted. A ** between dates indicates one class that meets twice.
Microsoft PowerPoint (IBM) 4:15 to 8:15 p.m. Tuesday Feb. 10, $100.
Microsoft Outlook (IBM) 9:15 to 11:15 a.m. Wednesday Feb. 11, $100.
Windows95 Wkshp (IBM) 2:15 to 4:15 p.m. Wednesday Feb. 11, $90.
Internet Introduction 4:15 to 8:15 p.m. Monday Feb. 16, $100.
Microsoft Word (IBM) 9:15 a.m. to 1:15 p.m. Tuesdays Feb. 17-24
Lotus 1,2,3 (IBM) 5:15 to 9:15 p.m. Tuesdays Feb. 17-24
Microsoft Works (IBM) 8:15 a.m. to 1:15 p.m. Wednesdays Feb. 18-25
Microsoft Excel (IBM) 4:15 to 8:15 p.m. Thursdays Feb. 19-26
Microsoft Access (IBM) 9:15 a.m. to 1:15 p.m. Fridays Feb. 20-27
WordBasics 9:15 to 11:15 a.m. Saturday Feb. 21, $80.
WordBasics/PLUS 1:15 to 3:15 p.m. Saturday Feb. 21, $60.
Scanner Wkshp 1:15 to 3:15 p.m. Monday Feb. 23, $60.
Creating WEB Pages 4:15 to 8:15 p.m. Monday Feb. 23, $100.
Windows95 Wkshp (IBM) 5:15 to 7:15 p.m. Wednesday Feb. 25, $50.
Quicken (IBM) 9:15 a.m. to 12:15 p.m. Thursday Feb. 26, $75.

Crossbow Community Computers
All classes are ongoing and are held at Crossbow Computers in Park Lane Mall on Tuesdays and Thursdays at 7 p.m. Cost unless otherwise stated: adults, $10 & Washoe County students, $5 student ID required. Reservations: 827-2121.
Intro to Computers. Windows 95. Introduction. Wordperfect. Introduction. WordPerfect. Advanced. 540. Intro to the Internet. The Internet: Creating Your Web Site. $75.

MicroAge
To be held at 3995 S. Virginia St. All seminars are from 6 to 8 p.m. and cost $40 unless otherwise stated. Training labs are from 8:30 a.m. to 4:30 p.m. and cost $146. Reservations: 850-7009.
Seminars: **Intro to Personal Computers** Feb. 10, free. **Intro to Windows 95** Feb. 16. **Intro to the Internet** Feb. 23. **Labs: Intermediate Microsoft Word 7.0** Feb. 9. **Intermediate Microsoft Excel 7.0** Feb. 16. **Introduction to Microsoft Word 7.0** Feb. 23.

Nevada Small Business Development Center
University of Nevada, Reno, Business Building, Room 312. All classes are on Thursday from 8:30 a.m. to 2:30 p.m. and cost $70 unless otherwise stated. Details: 784-1717.
Microsoft Excel: Basics Feb. 12. **Word: Intermediate** Feb. 19. **Excel: Intermediate** Feb. 26. **Microsoft Access: Basics** March 5. **Microsoft Access: Intermediate** March 12. **Microsoft PowerPoint: Intermediate** March 26. **Internet: Learn to Surf the Web** April 2. **WordPerfect: Intermediate** April 9.

Productivity Point International
To be held at 5301 Longley Lane. All classes are held from 8:30 a.m. to 4:30 p.m. and cost $165 unless otherwise stated. Details: 829-6300 ext. 30.
MS-Powerpoint 97: Introduction Feb. 11. **MS-Word v7.0: Introduction** Feb. 10. **Administering Microsoft NT 4.0** (Microsoft authorized course no. 803) Feb. 10-12; $1275.

TMCC Institute for Business & Industry
To be held at TMCC Old Town Mall. Details: 829-9000.
Powerpoint for Windows95 8 a.m. Feb. 17; $110. **Windows 95: Level I** 8 a.m. Feb. 17; $195. **Access for Windows 95: Level I** 5:30 p.m. Feb. 17; $135. **Web Page-HTML: Essentials** 5:30 p.m. Feb. 17; $155. **MS Word for Windows 95: Level I** 8 a.m. Feb. 18; $155. **WordPerfect for Windows 3.1: Level I** 8 a.m. Feb. 18; $110. **WordPerfect for Windows 95: Level I** 1 p.m. Feb. 18; $110. **Windows 95 Essentials: Experienced Users** 8 a.m. Feb. 19; $110. **Windows 95 Essentials: Beginners** 8 a.m. Feb. 19; $110. **Browsing & Building with Netscape** 1 p.m. Feb. 19; $110. **Personal Computing: Essentials** 1 p.m. Feb. 19; $110. **Excel for Windows 95: Level II** 8 p.m. Feb. 21; $135. **Surfing 101** 9 a.m. Feb. 21; $60.

University of Nevada, Reno Division of Continuing Education
Details: 784-4042.
Women's History Resources on the Internet Ways to search for specific women's history topics on local, national and international level. To be held 9 a.m. to 3 p.m. Feb. 21 & March 7 & 14 at the College of Education Building Computer Lab. A one credit course. Cost: undergraduate, $66.50 or graduate, $93. Registration deadline: Feb. 13.

HomeComputing

Do you need fancy tax-preparation software or a calculator?

By Larry Blasko
THE ASSOCIATED PRESS

Efforts are under way to make the IRS friendlier, probably changing its standard approach from "Stick 'Em Up!" to "Stick 'Em Up, Please!" Either way, we still must pay, and tax preparation software counts on that.

Three things to consider before you drop $30 to $50 on a tax preparation package:

1. Do I need this thing?

If you can file your return on form 1040EZ, or have few deductions, the answer is "no." You can do your return with a calculator. Sure, the preparation packages are convenient, and they do the math, and they're chock-full of forms and suggestions if you're running a business, or have capital gains, unreimbursed employee expenses and the like. But if you're using the package mostly as a calculator, ask yourself if you'd pay $50 for an ordinary calculator.

2. Do I have the necessary information online?

Part of the beauty of the packages is that they can look at the information in money-management software and automatically grab charitable deductions, interest income and other tax-related spending. If your information of that sort is stored in unopened bank statements at the bottom of your sock drawer, be advised that neither of the two leading packages, Intuit Inc.'s TurboTax Deluxe and Block Financial Corp.'s Kiplinger TaxCut, have sock-drawer interfaces.

3. Am I comfortable enough about finances to make the right choices?

Tax-preparation software "interviews" you to help you select appropriate forms and report income, but it's still just software. An accountant will ask a few follow-up questions if you list your dependents names as Spot, Rover and Kitty. Tax preparation software will happily move to the next question.

If you live in a state with an income tax, buying the add-on state package is worth it, particularly if your return is complicated. I live in New Jersey and work in New York City, so come April, New Jersey, New York State, New York City and Uncle Sam all have their hands out. Entering the basic information once for the feds and having it flow to the other beggars is a big time-saver.

Another nice thing about the tax preparation packages is they keep up with changes made in the tax laws, something Congress seems to do yearly for exercise, and help assure software firms of repeat business. The capital gains tax law in 1997, for example, is different from that of 1996.

Which package? Although it's often a close call, most have given the nod over the years to TurboTax (also MacIntax for the Maci and Kiplinger TaxCut, both of which keep improving their packages from year to year and are widely available at retail. Be certain to check system requirements, especially as they pertain to printers.

Both packages are saying on their Web sites that they plan to offer online filing this month, but I haven't tried it yet. Even with all the assurances about data security, I would still feel a bit uneasy, admittedly because this old dog sniffs new tricks with some suspicion.

Larry_Blasko@ap.org.

Black history online

By Bob Deitel
GANNETT NEWS SERVICE

Some of his earliest writings were love letters — letters he wrote for his Coast Guard buddies to send to their wives and girlfriends.

Who was he: Thurgood Marshall, Alex Haley or Benjamin Hooks? If you answered Haley, pat yourself on the back.

Then head to the World Wide Web to stretch your brain further and celebrate Black History Month.

The Web holds a fine selection of African-American history resources, beginning with the above question's home: www.gale.com/gale/bhm/blackhm.html That site — produced by Gale, a publisher of reference books and related material — offers a variety of ways to approach black history. Start with the question-a-day quiz.

Read the question and click on your answer. You'll be told if you're right and will be shown a photo and capsule biography of notables ranging from Alice Walker to Booker T. Washington. You can also choose to learn more about each person.

Or go straight to "biographies" to read about 60 figures from the arts, entertainment, sports, world affairs, human rights and history.

Other nifty stops at the site include "timeline," a 400-year chronology of milestones in African-American history. It starts in 1619 when 20 Africans arrived in Jamestown, Va., aboard a Dutch ship. They were the first blacks to be forcibly settled in the North American British colonies, the site says.

Teachers and families might also want to check out "activities," a listing of learn-it-yourself projects ranging from studying life along the Nile to creating an African window garden. Each topic comes with instructions and reference sources.



TREE OF KNOWLEDGE: The World Book's site (www.worldbook.com/ features/blackhistory/index.html) features links to interesting information. Below, some modern U.S.'s black history is hard to believe without the photographic proof. Below, police chief Bull Conner's police dogs attack peaceful demonstrators in Montgomery, Ala., in 1963.



This woman's shrine mask from Camaroon is one of many ceremonial masks at www.ipl.org/exhibit/maah/masks.html



This is an interesting cartooned version of Anansi. Traditionally, the spider is more stylized and African-art looking.

8-legged Trickster

In African folklore, Anansi the spider is a Trickster, somewhat like the Native American Coyote. The difference is that Anansi often is undone by his scheming, and his failures — often due to greed — are used as a moral of the tales.

You can find many Anansi tales through a search engine such as Alta Vista.



World Book encyclopedia also has a worthy Web site: The African-American Journey (www.worldbook.com/features/blackhistory/index.html). It presents a concise but fascinating on-screen journey filled with links to more information about people, countries and events. You can learn about the slave trade, the antislavery movement, the early years of freedom after the Civil War, the civil-rights movement and Black History Month itself.

For more intensive study, check out the black history educational activity center created by Pacific Bell (www.kn.pacbell.com/wired/BHM/AfroAm.html). The site lists projects and topics for discussion or writing and provides links to documents, memoirs and other resources. Or try "treasure hunt" and see if you can uncover even more African-American history.

For a brief final stop, try the interactive exhibits of the Black History Museum (www.afroam.org/history/history.html). Exhibits there include a page about the 1920s and '30s fad of trying to be whiter.

There's also an exhibit called This Is Our War, articles written by black news correspondents covering African-American troops during World War II. As the site says, "Don't miss this special glimpse into a little known part of black history!"

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black geeks online

Black Americans are as diverse as any other group of Americans. At left is the logo from the technology-interested Black Geeks Online, at www.blackgeeks.net/

African-American news

By Bill O'Brien
THE WASHINGTON POST

An array of Web sites helps African Americans on levels from employment opportunities to culture and literature.

One place to start is EverythingBlack (www.everythingblack. com), a sort of mega-mall home page. It displays 12 wide categories — from arts and humanities to business, entertainment and travel — that offer links to hundreds of Web sites, including African-American community news outlets.

There are many specialized sites, too. Mosaicbooks.com/The Black Literary Showcase (www.mosaicbooks.com), an affiliate of online bookstore Amazon. com, features summaries and recommendations on current black and Hispanic literature. Black Facts Online (www. blackfacts.com) is a database/ search engine that aspires to be "Your Internet Resource of Black History Information." Black Urban Professionals Online (www.buppie.com) provides parenting tips, a resume databank, guidance on personal finance, and professional and social calendars. The Black Collegian Online (www.black-collegian.com) offers career advice and a state-by-state job database. And that's just a smattering.

Test your knowledge of black history with quick quiz

If you'd like to test your knowledge of African-American issues and achievements, here is a quiz.

QUESTION: When and where was the first reading of the Emancipation Proclamation?

ANSWER: Jan. 1, 1863, in Port Royal, S.C.

Q. Who is known as "father of the Civil Rights Movement"?

A. Abolitionist Frederick Douglass, who was born into slavery in 1817.

Q. When was the nation's first all-black classical ballet company founded?

A. The Dance Theatre of Harlem began in 1971.

Q. Who was the first African-American singer to perform with the New York Metropolitan Opera company?

A. Marian Anderson in 1955.

Q. Who was the first African-American woman to speak out publicly against slavery?

A. Sojourner Truth in the 1840s. Her famous "Ain't I a Woman" speech was given in Akron, Ohio, in 1851.

Q. How did the nation's first self-made woman millionaire make her fortune?

A. Madame C.J. Walker invented a hair softener and straightening combs for African-American women in 1905.

Q. Who was the first jazz singer, known as "empress of the blues?"

A. Bessie Smith, who first played with Louis Armstrong in 1925 and became Columbia Records' best-selling artist in the '20s.

Q. What athlete broke major league baseball's color barrier?

A. Jackie Robinson, who joined the Brooklyn Dodgers in 1947, becoming the first African-American baseball player with the majors in modern times. Robinson was inducted into the Baseball Hall of Fame in 1962.

Q. What was the first African-American newspaper in the United States?

A. Freedom's Journal, established by Samuel Eli Cornish and John Russwurm in 1827.

Q. Who was known as the "Brown Bomber"?

A. Boxing champion Joe Louis, the first African American to become a national idol, who defeated Jimmy Braddock in 1937 to become heavyweight champion of the world.

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